PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Ford Bronco (1966–1977)

1966–1977 · U13 · U14 · U15

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust, everywhere, even in dry states**
  Autotrader Classics calls rust the biggest concern and warns that surface rust can hide serious rot. Check the rocker panels and the floor pans they join, the cargo floor (especially where it meets the half-cab wall), the door posts around the hinges, the firewall and inner fenders, the tailgate and the frame rails. Velocity Restorations notes that structural rust can cost more than it's worth to fix.

- [ ] **Cut or uncut rear fenders**
  Many early Broncos had their rear fenders cut to fit flares and bigger tires. Uncut trucks are rarer and worth more, and flared trucks sell for less. Look closely at the quarter panels for filler or patched-in arches.

- [ ] **Frame at the steering box**
  Wild Horses points out that the frame takes a lot of load where the steering box bolts on, and that area can weaken or crack. With the engine running, have someone turn the wheel and watch the box. If it moves on the frame, check for cracks before you buy.

- [ ] **Does it drive straight?**
  A wandering early Bronco usually has the wrong caster, according to Wild Horses, especially after a lift with the wrong C-bushings. Lean of 2 inches or more is common after a suspension change. Neither is expensive to fix, but both tell you how carefully the truck was built.

- [ ] **VIN and data plate**
  The VIN is stamped on the frame rail, just ahead of the firewall under the engine, and the full data plate is inside the glovebox door. Check that they match the title. The first three characters give the series (U13, U14 or U15) and the fourth the engine code; a mismatch is common after decades of swaps, which matters most on a claimed original.

- [ ] **Baja, Sport and Ranger claims**
  Only 650 Baja Broncos were sold, and they now bring far more than a standard truck, so clones exist. Ask for documentation of any special edition. The data plate and VIN won't prove a Baja by themselves, so lean on build records and a marque specialist.

- [ ] **Who built it?**
  Most early Broncos for sale are modified, and many are full restomods. Velocity Restorations suggests asking what was done and by whom, whether there is documentation, whether the frame has been repaired or replaced, and how it drives at highway speed. A cheap build can cost more over time than a good one.

- [ ] **Hard-to-find parts**
  Mechanical parts are easy because the trucks use common Ford engines and Dana axles. Autotrader notes that thin steel grilles dent easily and are often cut for plows or PTO gear, and good tailgates are also scarce. Price those in if they're bad.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Steering drag-link connection**
  1967 · NHTSA 66V026000
- [ ] **Brake pedal and linkage**
  1967 · NHTSA 66V004003
- [ ] **Tires (tread / belt)**
  1970–1971 · NHTSA 70V113000
- [ ] **Exhaust system**
  1975 · NHTSA 76V015000
- [ ] **Aftermarket mechanical fuel pumps (Federal-Mogul)**
  1975–1977 · NHTSA 07E064000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **VIN layout**
  Eleven characters, such as U15GL followed by six serial digits. Positions 1–3 are the series: U13 roadster, U14 half-cab pickup, U15 wagon. Position 4 is the engine: F for the 170 six, S for the 200 six, N for the 289 and G for the 302. Position 5 is the plant, L for Michigan Truck. The model year is worked out from the serial range.
- [ ] **Where to look**
  The VIN is stamped on the frame rail under the engine, just ahead of the firewall; with the wheel turned fully right it can be seen from the wheel well. The full data plate is inside the glovebox door, with codes for paint, body, transmission, axle and sales district.
- [ ] **Axle code**
  The data plate's axle code gives the ratio and whether there's a limited-slip: CJ Pony's 1968 decoder lists 3.50, 4.11 and 4.57 ratios, with separate codes for the limited-slip versions. On the truck itself, the Dana 30 front has king pins and the Dana 44 has ball joints.
- [ ] **Transfer-case shifter**
  A straight up-and-down T-handle means a 1966–72 Dana 20 with a 2.46:1 low. A backward-J pattern means a 1973–77 case with 2.34:1. Rebuild parts differ between them.
- [ ] **Front brakes and steering**
  Factory front discs and a Y-type tie rod mean 1976–77 hardware. Earlier trucks with discs have been converted. Many trucks of every year now carry aftermarket steering linkage.
- [ ] **Special editions**
  Baja Broncos (650 sold) and other high-value trucks are worth faking, and the VIN alone won't prove one. Ask for build documentation and get a marque specialist to inspect it.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/bronco/early-bronco/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks